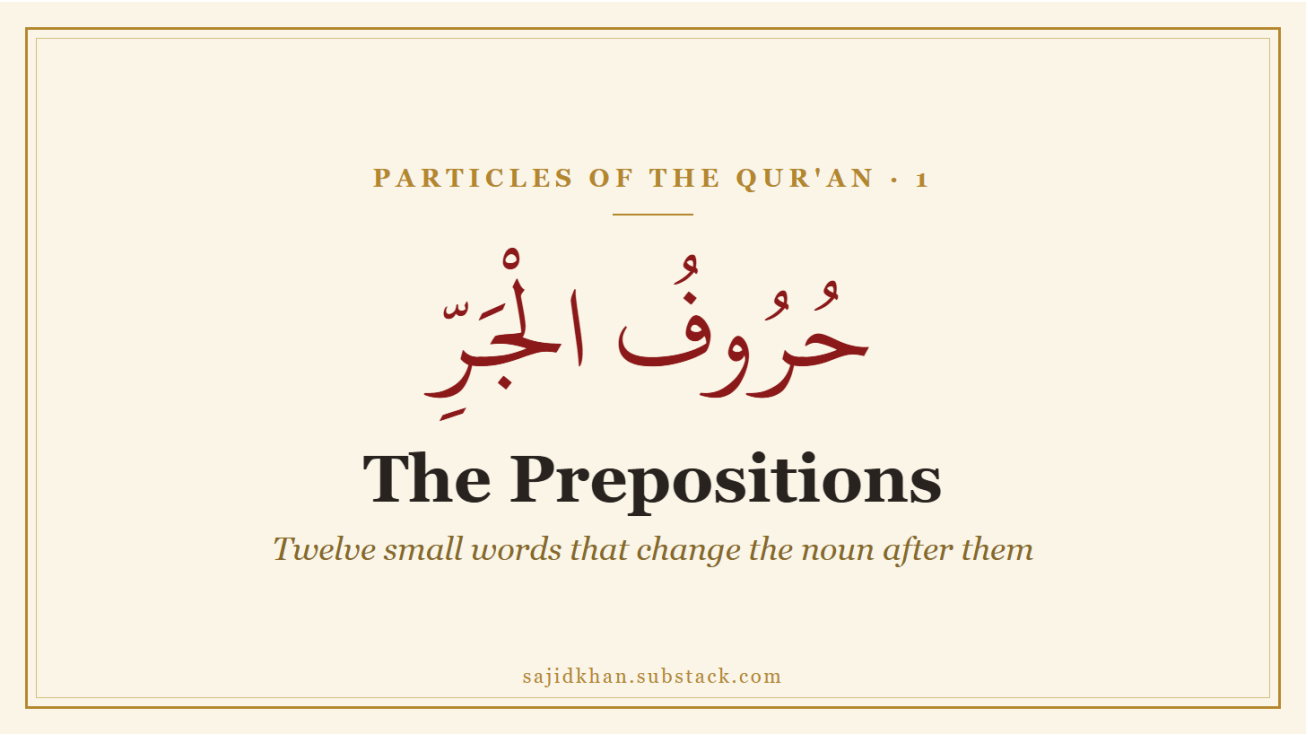


PARTICLES OF THE QUR'AN

Particles of the Qur'an 1: The Prepositions

Twelve small words that change the noun after them

Particles of the Qur'an, part 1 of 5

Arabic has three kinds of word: nouns, verbs and particles (*huroof*, حُرُوف). Particles are the small words: "in", "from", "not", "that", "so". They are few, but they are everywhere, and many of them change the ending of the next word. This short series goes through them one group at a time.

Two kinds of particle

- **Active particles** (*al-huroof al-'aamilah*, الْحُرُوفُ الْعَامِلَةُ, "the working particles"): they change the case of the noun after them (nominative, accusative, genitive) or the mood of the verb after them (indicative, subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب), jussive).
- **Inactive particles** (*al-huroof ghayr al-'aamilah*, الْحُرُوفُ غَيْرُ الْعَامِلَةِ, "the non-working particles"): they add meaning but change no endings.

The prepositions

The first group of active particles are the prepositions, *huroof al-jarr* (حُرُوفُ الْجَرِّ, "the pulling particles"). The noun after a preposition is genitive: it usually ends in kasra. The preposition and its noun together are called *jaar wa majroor* (جَارّ وَمَجْرُور, "the puller and the pulled").

1. **with, in:** بِ (*bi*). بِسْمِ اللَّهِ "in the name of Allah" (1:1).
2. **by (an oath, with Allah only):** تَ (*ta*). تَاللَّهِ "by Allah" (12:85).
3. **like:** كَ (*ka*). مَثَلُ نُورِهِ كَمِشْكَاةٍ فِيهَا مِصْبَاحٌ "the example of His light is like a niche in which there is a lamp" (24:35).
4. **for, to:** لِ (*li*). فَصَلِّ لِرَبِّكَ "so pray to your Lord" (108:2).
5. **by (an oath):** وَ (*wa*). وَالنَّازِعَاتِ غَرْقًا "by those who pull out violently" (79:1).
6. **far be it:** حَاشَا (*haashaa*), shortened in the Qur'an to حَاشَ. حَاشَ لِلَّهِ "Allah forbid!" (12:31).
7. **from:** مِنْ (*min*). الْقَوَاعِدَ مِنَ الْبَيْتِ "the foundations of the House" (2:127).
8. **about:** عَنْ (*'an*). عَنِ النَّعِيمِ "about the blessings" (102:8).
9. **on, upon:** عَلَى (*'alaa*). وَإِنَّهُ عَلَىٰ ذَٰلِكَ لَشَهِيدٌ "and he is a witness to that" (100:7).
10. **until:** حَتَّى (*hattaa*). حَتَّىٰ زُرْتُمُ الْمَقَابِرَ "until you visit the graves" (102:2).
11. **in:** فِي (*fee*). فِي الدُّنْيَا وَالْآخِرَةِ "in this world and the Hereafter" (2:220).
12. **to, towards:** إِلَى (*ilaa*). وَإِلَىٰ رَبِّكَ فَارْغَبْ "and to your Lord turn all your attention" (94:8).

One thing to notice

Look at the noun right after each preposition: اسْمِ "name", نُورِهِ "His light", مِشْكَاةٍ "a niche", رَبِّكَ "your Lord", الْبَيْتِ "the House", النَّعِيمِ "the blessings", الْمَقَابِرَ "the graves". All end in kasra except the last. الْمَقَابِرَ "graves" is a plural pattern that never takes kasra, so its genitive is shown with a fatha. You will meet these nouns again later.

Next: the four particles that change the ending of a verb from *-u* to *-a*.

From my book Quran Grammar Summary *(second edition), section 1.5.*

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